
PO33Q - The Life and Death of Democracies and Autocracies: A Quantitative Perspective

AI Policy

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This document outlines the module's policy for the use of Artificial Intelligence (AI). Please read it carefully.

Before I outline the policy let me just ask you this: why have you come to university? Why have you taken this module? The answer to both of these questions is probably (hopefully!) that you wanted to learn something new. A lot of you will have selected this module to brush up on quantitative skills for employability reasons. You will not learn anything, substantively, methodologically, or in terms of coding if you ask Claude, ChatGPT, or any of the other chat bots out there to write your report or your code for you. Even in the unlikely case that a violation of this policy will elude my detection, saving you from a very uncomfortable academic misconduct process, you will not acquire any new skills from this module, and selecting it will have been absolutely pointless. To cite Blackadder, "a strategically shaved monkey" can operate an AI chat. You did not have to come to university for that. If you are aiming for graduate level employment, it is graduate level skills that will get you through the assessment centres, not your ability to chat with Claude. Having said all this, especially in coding the use of AI *can* be incredibly helpful and time-saving. I have therefore opted for a permissive policy that allows you to use AI in certain ways, but not in others.

On PO33Q, you are allowed to use AI models in the following ways:

- You should use AI to supplement your learning, not to replace it. AI can provide valuable insights and explanations, but it should not be your primary source of information.
- Always verify information provided by AI. While AI models can be very accurate, they can also make mistakes, or even hallucinate. Double-check all facts and figures from reliable sources.
- Research and study themes and issues relating to the module (e.g., conversing with AI to learn more about particular concepts, or statistical methods).
- Use AI to develop your ideas about issues raised in the module, including ideas that you intend to use in assessed work (e.g., using AI to help develop or clarify your understanding of unobserved heterogeneity, or to discuss how neopatrimonialism has been measured in the quantitative democratisation literature).
- Use AI to check R code and to debug faulty code.
- A ChatGPT conversation is not a permissible reference in an assessment. But you can ask ChatGPT for the sources of the information it uses in a conversation. Then verify the information and use the original source as a reference.

The primary goal of this module is to make you into a competent, independent researcher. AI should be used as a tool to enhance your learning, not as a substitute for your own intellectual effort.

What does this mean for the assignments?

- For the Annotated R Script:
 - While it is acceptable to use AI to gain understanding of coding in R, you are **not allowed** to use AI to write your R code or the annotations for you. You may use AI to check your code and debug it if you encounter errors that you cannot resolve yourself. However, the code you submit must be your own work.
- For the Research Project:
 - While it is acceptable to use AI to develop and refine your ideas and understanding of both substantive and methodological questions pertaining to the project, **you are expressly forbidden** from using AI to **write** your assessment.
- All assessed work will be screened for AI use using a combination of automated detection tools and manual review. Misuse of AI in violation of this policy will be referred to the academic misconduct committee and may result in penalties ranging from a reduced grade to failure of the assignment, depending on the severity of the offence.
- Please also refer to the [Marking Guidance](#) for this module, where I explain how several of its pillars already assess practices that support academic integrity.

Specific examples of the policy

- **“I had a conversation with ChatGPT to find academic articles on neopatrimonialism. This helped me to understand the topic better. Was that allowed?”**

Absolutely fine. This is an excellent way to use AI for research and understanding.
- **“I was a little unclear after reading the companion if I understood correctly what a fixed effects model is and asked Claude. Is that OK?”**

Again, that is absolutely fine. But please don't forget that Flo is there to help, as well — both in seminars and in office hours.
- **“I had discussions with AI to develop my understanding of what a research puzzle is. I wanted to see if my understanding was correct. Some of the ideas we discussed were subsequently used in my essay. Is this acceptable?”**

Yes, it is. Using AI to develop and refine your ideas is encouraged, as long as the assessment is your own piece of work, and you do not copy/paste answers into your assessment.
- **“I have asked ChatGPT to write me the R code for the model summary table. Is that OK?”**

No, because the code you submit in the annotated R Script, and also as part of your research project, must be your own work. You may use AI to check your code and debug it if you encounter errors that you cannot resolve yourself.
- **“While I was writing my essay, I used AI to help me clean up some of the sentences, make suggestions for placeholders, and check my grammar. Is that ok?”**

No, because then AI would be writing at least some elements of your assessment.

- **“I asked AI to write the literature review of my report. Was it ok to do this?”**

No, this is a breach of the policy and your essay will be flagged for academic misconduct.

- **“I asked AI to generate a 3,000-word research project. Does this breach the policy?”**

You are kidding, right?